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Steve Wilson

Saxophonist Steve Wilson was born in Hampton, Virginia on February 9, 1961. He graduated from Virginia Commonwealth University in 1985 and moved to New York shortly thereafter. He has performed with Lionel Hampton, Chic Corea and the Smithsonian Jazz Masterworks Orchestra. Steve currently leads his own quartet and records for Stretch and Criss Cross Records.

Steve was interviewed in Clinton, New York on October 25, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive on the Hamilton campus and I'm very pleased to have Steve Wilson with me today, and welcome to the college.

SW: Thank you. Nice to be here.

MR: It's great to hear you and your band talk about what you do and where it comes from. And I'll start off with something really easy, like whatever possessed you to try to make a living in the jazz world?

SW: That's a good question. You know I think it was just being inspired very young, being exposed to the music by my father, who is a music enthusiast and had all kinds of music around the house. The first record I remember hearing live was Ahmad Jamal "Live at the Pershing" and of course with "Poinciana" and Miles Davis "Live in Europe." But there were other things, you know Miriam Makeba, James Brown, he was a big Mario Lanza fan, so there was a whole array of music, and seeing music live when I was small in Hampton, Virginia at the Hampton Jazz Festival, and seeing people like Cannonball Adderley, Eddie Harris, Les McCann, Rahsaan Roland Kirk. Getting all of that early is what inspired me to do it. So I pretty much knew by the time I was twelve or thirteen, this is something I really loved and wanted to do it.

MR: Did your father play an instrument?

SW: No. He sang in a spiritual choir, but not a trained musician. I did have other relatives who were musicians and all of my friends in the neighborhood played music so with all of that it inspired me to do it.

MR: Did your parents — were they supportive in your choice?

SW: Yeah. Actually they were. I think not until I was eighteen did they really begin to take me seriously as someone who wanted to do this professionally. I think, as any parent, you think okay well they're going to go through several phases. But no, even as a teenager I was playing in garage bands and playing in R&B bands and disco bands and going out

Elks lodges, the whole thing. So yeah, by the time I was eighteen and started to do it they thought okay, this is what he's really going to do.

MR: Yeah it always helps when you're bringing home a few dollars.

SW: Yeah.

MR: And sometimes if you're lucky a musician can make in one night what your friends might be taking a few days at the garage.

SW: That's right. That's right. Especially as a teenager, and I didn't have to ask my parents for money all the time. So it worked out.

MR: Was there thought that maybe you should get a teaching degree in music, just in case?

SW: Yeah, not so much from them, I mean I was advised by a few people to think about that and even some of the instructors I had in college. I never really thought about that to tell you the truth, and quite honestly, ironically, I now find if I'm ever giving advice to students that's one of the things that I suggest. And if I had to do it all over again that's probably the thing that I would do. I would probably do like either a teaching or composition degree. Because if you're going to go to college in music, as a music major, you're going to perform anyway. So certainly I think teaching, having a teaching degree is, yeah, it's great.

MR: And you got a degree in performance?

SW: Yeah.

MR: Right. Yeah you never know what you're going to want to do like when you're fifty.

SW: Exactly.

MR: I suppose.

SW: And I tell students all the time now that look, even if you go into your career as a performer and it's wonderful, it's great, but at some point when you get to be forty something, fifty something, the road is not going to be as romantic anymore. It wears off. So you're going to start to think about things like yeah I'd like to be home more, I'd like to have a family, or something like that. So have some options.

MR: What brought you to the saxophone? Was it your first instrument?

SW: Yeah. Formally anyway. I really wanted to be a drummer, before the age of twelve. But I think what changed me to saxophone was hearing the record "Swiss Movement," Les McCann and Eddie Harris. Because that was a big hit around 1969, 1970, and that was one of the records my father had and I gravitated toward that. And then with allowance money I started going out and buying a couple of Eddie Harris records and of course Cannonball Adderley's "Country Preacher" was a big hit at the time. So all of those things, I said oh this is — I like the way this sounds. I like the way this feels.

MR: Yeah. We're going to talk about those guys in a while actually.

MR: Some of my favorites too. When you were in college, this was still in Virginia, right?

SW: Richmond. Richmond, Virginia.

MR: Was there this thought in your mind that eventually I'm going to go to New York City?

SW: Yeah pretty much. I knew that I would eventually have to go to New York to pursue the music, I mean once my love for the music really developed while I was in college. Because we had people coming through all the time. We had — my first week of school Elvin Jones came through in a band he had with Andrew White and Ari Brown. Sonny Rollins came through a couple of years later, and people like Frank Foster, Jackie Byard, the Heath Brothers, they all came in for a week residency. Benny Carter also came in. And all directions at that time pointed to New York. Now I do want to say at that time Richmond was a great place to be. The music scene was really happening. We had three big bands at school. The director of the program at the time, Doug Richards, dealt with Duke Ellington, particularly early Duke Ellington, as a cornerstone of the program. So there wasn't just everything post-1950 or post-1960. We dealt with the early jazz as much as we did Thad Jones and Mary Lou Williams and other things. We covered the whole history. But yeah I knew pretty much around 1985 I would have to go to New York, at least to give it a try. And to go and play with the musicians that I had been admiring and listening to, and sort of seek them out. So yeah.

MR: Did you arrive with any contacts in place?

SW: Yeah. Fortunately. I had just joined a band called Out of the Blue, which was a young lions group put together by Blue Note Records at the time. And I replaced Kenny Garrett who had gone on to join Art Blakey and then subsequently Miles. So I was in that band when I got to New York but the band didn't have any work. So I had to start all over again. While I was living in Virginia I was in a fusion group that was working all the time and I was working other jazz gigs, so I gave all of that up to move to New York. But it was worth it because I went out and sat in with different people and met a lot of different people, sitting in with people like Jon Faddis or David Murray, Hamiet Bluiett had a band at the time called the Telepathic Orchestra with younger and older musicians in the band so I had contacts in a lot of different areas moving in.

MR: What kind of places did those jam sessions happen in back then? Were they small clubs and that kind of thing?

SW: Let's see, well the late 1980s we're talking like the Blue Note had a late night jam session, like after the last show during the week and so usually starting at 1:00. And people like Justin Robertson and the Harper Brothers were heading those jam sessions. Then there was a jam session uptown at this place called Augie's, which is now called Smoke. But Augie's was a place where a lot of guys honed their craft, guys like Larry

Billy Drummond, a lot of the young musicians would just go up and play all the time. The Village — not the Village Vanguard but the other club—

MR: The Village Gate?

SW: The Village Gate had some stuff going. Then they had another club uptown near Columbia University that also had some sessions, and of course my good friend and partner Bruce Barth, we met around that time and started jamming together at his house. And his wife was kind enough to let us all come over a couple of times a week and play. And we've been working together now for like fourteen years as a result of that. So yeah it happened in a variety of clubs.

MR: That tradition of kind of getting into jam sessions and hopefully proving yourself has been around for a long time. In the late eighties was the repertoire that you're expected to know, was it still the standards?

SW: Oh yeah. And that was probably one of the first things that hit me when I moved to New York was having to learn those standards or re-learn them. I had been learning some of these tunes, some of the Monk tunes and some of the tunes of the American Songbook before I moved there but man these musicians, these young musicians knew all of these tunes inside and out. So it really forced me to build my repertoire and it was very healthy to do that. It forced me to do it.

MR: Did anybody ever call things like in non-standard keys?

SW: Occasionally yeah. It didn't happen too much but when I started working with vocalists.

MR: Oh right.

SW: And then of course they'll call "All the Things You Are" in F, instead of A flat. Oh yeah, what's the first chord. So yeah.

MR: Was there any — I'm not sure what word to use — competitiveness or even unpleasant atmosphere in some of those sessions, like people trying to make you look foolish?

SW: You know I didn't experience that. I had heard of certain sessions or certain people that could be that way but I didn't experience that particularly. One thing, it was very healthy that you were around great players who either had more ability or more knowledge, and so I saw it as very healthy because it was a reference of what one needed to go home and work on. So yeah, I certainly got my behind kicked many times in jam sessions and probably still would, still do. There's a lot I don't know. But that's the healthy part of music. That's what keeps us humble. That's what keeps us growing. We never know it all.

MR: Off the top of your head, what are let's say five tunes that you better know inside and out if you're going to get up on a jam session?

SW: Well there's standard rhythm changes, of course in B flat but be ready to do them in any

a couple of American Songbook standards, you know, "Green Dolphin Street," "All the Things You Are." But basically those three, those first three. And of course well you could throw "Giant Steps" in there because eventually somebody's going to throw that at you.

MR: Really?

SW: Yeah. One of the tunes, actually one of the tunes that I had never really learned when I first moved to New York and it got called on me a couple of times was — what's the title of it — [scats]. I can't think of the title of it now unfortunately [scats].

MR: I guess I don't know it either.

SW: Yeah I'm getting bad with titles. But I went home and learned that off a Dexter Gordon record because someone called it on me at a jam session one night and I thought okay. And I remember Harold Mabern telling me some years later, when he was in Chicago cutting his teeth and it happened to him all the time. And he says, "Yeah well you know first time shame on you, second time shame on me." So he said yeah, whenever that happens go home and learn that tune immediately. Oh, "It's You or No One."

MR: Okay.

SW: So yeah, I learned from that experience.

MR: Like you can never know all of them it seems like.

SW: It's impossible. As a matter of fact I occasionally play with a great guitarist named Peter Leitch. He has a regular Sunday night gig in New York at a place called Walker's. Just a duo. And every week he has somebody different. And I do the gig like every couple of months and it's good for that because Peter knows a million tunes in any key, and he knows these obscure tunes that nobody knows, all of these different Broadway tunes. So just last week I played with him again and I remember the time before that his wife Sylvia had asked me if I knew one of the tunes from "Kismet," "Stranger in Paradise." So I went out and I bought the record and I learned it. Now I learned it in the original key which was G flat. And of course when I got on the gig, Peter is playing it in F. Okay, here we go. But that's part of the music.

MR: Right. I sometimes feel sorry for the bass players at sessions. For one thing they have to play forever, plus it seems to me as a horn player you can kind of — well you don't have to know the roots all the time. You can negotiate with your ear somewhat. But the bass player, I hope he knows the changes.

SW: Yeah. Well you know ironically that's what I'm listening for is roots most of the time. And when I'm learning tunes I do it in two ways. I go to the piano and learn what the root movement is, I learn the chords and then the melody. So that way I can correlate the melody with the root movement. So whenever I'm caught in a situation where I'm not

hear one or the other I'm really lost. I'm like okay well I'm just out there. But it's saved me more than a few times.

MR: Did you have to work non-music jobs during this time in New York?

SW: Not in New York. While I was in school I did work a non-music job, I worked in a hospital as a stock clerk on weekends. I had to work every weekend and holidays, which was rough, because a lot of times on holidays you want to go home to visit your family, that kind of thing. So there were times I couldn't do that, and I was always playing music on the weekends. So I went to work from eight to five and then I would play a gig from maybe eight to twelve or nine to one, and get up on Sunday morning and go back to the hospital. So yeah, I paid a few dues. And before that actually in high school I was a shoe salesman and I washed dishes for one night at a chain called Bennigan's Tavern. And luckily I had just auditioned for a disco band and the very day that I got hired to wash dishes I found out later that evening that they had hired me, the disco band decided that they wanted me to play with them. So I quit the job the next day.

MR: Right. Well having those kinds of jobs helps keep things in perspective, doesn't it?

SW: Absolutely. Yeah. I think when we're talking about playing music or being an artist of any kind, we're talking about humility and humanity. And we have to remember that we're communicating. When we're performing we're communicating with people who, 99% of your audience is nonmusicians. So we're really trying to communicate to everybody. So sometimes as artists we tend to take these things for granted and what people do in their daily lives. So I think it really keeps us connected with that. Absolutely.

MR: Did you have a time when you felt this is my break? A phone call or an opportunity to play with someone that you felt was really a door opener for you?

SW: Yeah. I've had that several times throughout my career. Well even my first gig out of high school which was that disco group that traveled along the East Coast. Because that was my dream at the time was to just get out and travel and play music every night. It didn't matter what kind of music, I just wanted to play. So even that experience represented that to me. And then my first year in college I got a call from a friend of mine who was working with Stephanie Mills, who at the time had just come off of the lead in "The Wiz," which of course was the Broadway version of "The Wizard of Oz," and she was going out as a solo R&B artist. And he says, "Hey man, we need some horn players, would you like to come audition for the band?" And that was my first trip to New York. Went there and did it, went on the road with her for a year and went back to school. Then playing with Out of the Blue starting in 1986, getting that call. And then after moving to New York getting a call to play with Lionel Hampton. And it just keeps going. So every

opportunity that comes I felt like yeah, this is the door I've been looking to open. And it's kept going that way.

MR: It probably will never end.

SW: Exactly. Exactly. Which is the beauty of it. Now I do have a bit more perspective on the music business per se and so I'm not as excited as say when I was eighteen because I'm looking at it more as a professional musician. But nonetheless it continues to steer my hunger for the music and to broaden my musical relationships.

MR: What was it like working with Gates?

SW: Wow.

MR: Did he call you Gates by the way?

SW: Oh yeah, oh yeah, oh yeah. Yeah. Everybody was Gates. Everybody was Gates. Well I was going to school in a number of ways, learning the ways of the road, learning that there were guys on that gig who were much older than I was at the time and some of the things that would get me a bit irate, you know some of the working conditions, and to see these guys to not get so mad. And they just had a better understanding of the big picture. Of course when you're in your twenties you want it all right now and you want everything to happen, and you want everything to be right. But also from Gates himself, I mean he gave a hundred percent every night when he came on the stage. He was an amazing performer and he was into his eighties by the time I was working with him. And he would take various medications depending on the state of his health to keep him up or whatever. But no matter what condition he was in he always came out to perform, he never shortchanged the audience. Never. So I learned, that was the most valuable thing I learned from watching him. And he was a great musician. And a lot of people don't know. I mean people who see him as just a performer, he was really a great musician. He knew a lot about music, he knew a lot of music, and I've listened to some of the earlier records now from the thirties and forties that he's done and he was a great contributor to this music, absolutely.

MR: He knew his theory too I think, from some of the things I've read.

SW: Yeah, yeah. I think a lot of the musicians of my generation tend to dismiss him because he didn't play in a so-called modern vernacular. Like things, the post bebop vernacular. But it's not about that. I mean you listen to those records and believe me there's more than enough information that we could all learn from that he was disseminating. So absolutely.

MR: Well what is post bebop vernacular for you?

SW: Particularly, like yesterday we were talking about Coltrane. So I'm thinking more of the hard bop, from the mid-fifties on like Sonny Rollins, Art Blakey and the Jazz

Thinking more in terms of the post — from the mid-fifties on. And of course even now you've got so many great young players out here who have learned that part of the language. What I find in my experiences as an educator and as a musician is that again a lot of people who are say forty and under haven't bothered to get what Kenny Washington called pre-bop. And music before Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie. And I'm thinking of people like Benny Carter, Chu Berry, Fletcher Henderson, all of the great big bands, even all of the soloists in the Ellington bands at the time. Sidney Bechet. Those were incredible improvisers. They were absolutely incredible. I mean amazingly inventive. And of course the language that they were dealing with, the musical language, is not as complex harmonically necessarily as say bebop on. But rhythmically it's very, very complex. And melodically it's so fluid. I mean we were talking earlier about the people like Kenny Davern and Joe Wilder. Joe Wilder, who I absolutely love. And I've had the good fortune of working with him on several occasions. I saw a concert of his recently at NYU and he was just amazing. And it sounded so modern.

MR: Really.

SW: You know not in the sense of like well yeah it's the coming out of a Woody Shaw thing or a Freddy Hubbard thing. No. But in his own language, in his own syntax. And he played some things that made us all raise our eyebrows, what was that? Where did he find that? How did he pull that out of the air? So we tend to dismiss some of these musicians that we don't associate with a modern Coltrane era. But I would beg to differ that they are just as relevant as anybody in the modern era.

MR: Plus what you can learn from a guy like Joe from his everyday life and his character.

SW: That's right. He is the gentleman's gentleman. Never leaves the house without a suit and tie on. Always a perfect gentleman. And loves a great joke and loves to play practical jokes on people. And you know, he's been through a lot in his career. He was doing it when there weren't — when we didn't have the modern conveniences we have now, and there's not one bitter bone in his body. And he continues to just represent the best of what this music is. So I love him, I really do.

MR: He's been here, by the way, a couple of times. I agree man, he's one of the best.

SW: Yeah. He always, whenever he shows up it's like we're all going to be graced with his presence.

MR: Yeah. You know there's people, him and Milt Hinton, and a number of others who just have this, you feel better when you're around them.

SW: Absolutely.

MR: And what a great way to be.

SW: Absolutely. You know great music changes the way we can feel about ourselves and

like being around people like Benny Carter and Joe Wilder, and I had the chance to, actually I shared a floor with Milt Hinton for a few months. We both had our practice studios where the musicians union building is now in New York City. That was where A&R Studios was for many years. And on the fifth floor there was a radio network for the blind. And they had several vacant spaces and I shared a rehearsal room with a guy, and Milt's room was right next door. And I got to see him a couple of times there. And he was just wonderful, just absolutely wonderful. So getting a chance to be around those kind of people keeps you humble. Because we tend to, in this modern era so to speak, we tend to have this sense of entitlement. And then you see these guys who have really paved the way for us to be doing what we're doing. And it's like okay, now, okay, I've got it. I really understand what it's all about.

MR: Well it seems like the business has changed pretty rapidly. Like you probably have an agent? You have a manager. In years past a guy like Milt Hinton probably would do his own booking. Are there advantages and/or disadvantages to the way things are now?

SW: Yeah. The scene is totally changed. Even in the last twenty years. It's become much more industry driven. By that I mean record companies, particularly major record companies, booking agents, presenters, and I'm thinking of like festival presenters, club owners, have had a big influence and I think to a degree too much influence on who, which musicians get exposed. Prior to the 1980s, the music always took care of that. It was the relationships that you forged and the music. So when we talk about people like Milt Hinton, George Duvivier, you know, they were doing record sessions all the time. They were great professional musicians. They could play anything at any time. So they could go out and play clubs, they could go out and do road gigs with big bands or singers, go in the studio, you know, and sight read, cut something right there on the spot. And that all but disappeared after the 1960s, 1970s. So guys like myself coming in in the 1980s we had to find other ways of doing it. Now of course when I came to New York the "young lions" thing was in full bloom.

MR: Who started that by the way? Anybody know?

SW: Well that point is often debated and discussed. I don't think it was any one person. I think it was a combination of forces. Generally speaking, and I'm not going to say that Wynton Marsalis is responsible for that, he's not. Because when Wynton came on the scene it actually was responsible for a lot of young guys like myself having an interest in the music. And seeing a guy from our generation who could play and had a great love and respect for the music certainly had an effect on many of us. So I think — and on some level he's responsible for the way that young musicians that came through having a sense of tradition and history of the music. But on the other hand the industry, the same

get a record deal, or to be able to record as a leader. So by the time the late 80s came around, early 90s, you had musicians who had never played with anybody and were getting signed to major record deals. People who had never served any apprenticeship. And that's not the way this music has evolved. It's always evolved by way of apprenticeships and the oral tradition, where you go and learn from the older musicians and spend time with them and go on the road with them and get knocked around and learn tunes and learn how to be a total musician. Learn how to play in the big band, learn how to play in the studio. So that — the rules changed. The rules changed drastically from like the 80s on. And now it's going through another transition because all of this big industry stuff is now going by the wayside. Where you have people like SONY Records and Verve that dropped a lot of artists in recent months. So I think this can turn into a positive because it puts the music back into the hands of the musicians. And if we just take care of the music and take care of each other, and not put so much credence into what *Down Beat* magazine says or what SONY Records says or whatever agency or festival says about yeah well this is the hot young guy right now, this is who we should be listening to and who we should be booking. No. The music always determines that. It's always about the music. It's not about the industry, it's about the music.

MR: If you can picture a bunch of suits sitting around a table in those days, what kind of factors did the musicians feel were being focused on, to anoint somebody? I don't know if I asked that very well.

SW: You mean in the days prior to date?

MR: Yeah. During this young lions thing. Why would certain people get picked?

SW: Well usually for non-musical reasons. It was either the way they looked, if they had a certain look, if they represented record sales — because record companies think in terms of demographics, who can we sell this product to, who can we sell this music to. And there was a time in the 80s where jazz became — there was renewed interest in the music, particularly in Japan. In Europe. Where there was a huge market for the music during the 1980s. Japan was experiencing an economic boom. I went there many times during that time. And the average jazz fan in Japan would know every record you've ever done. They'd know the catalogue number, they'd know what date it was recorded on. They'd know who else was on the record, where you were born. Wow I did all of that? And they'd know everything. And the same thing in Europe. You have this allegiance to the music. So certainly in America there was a renewed interest amongst younger people and it became kind of hip when yuppies were having fun and making money and it became a hip thing to be a part of. So the suits are certainly seeing all of this and going hey, this is a potential audience we can sell it to. But as it went along it didn't become —

They are young, we can sell to young people. So in too many instances it was done for non-musical reasons. And that's really the truth about it. Not always, but quite often it was.

MR: Was there a racial issue in any of this?

SW: I don't know, quite honestly. I suppose that there is or was. I mean because we're talking about America and race is always an issue one way or another. I have never felt it particularly in my own experience in dealing with record companies or industry people or even other musicians. I've never thought in terms of race, in terms of who do I want to play with. The only black and white I care about is the music on the page, personally. But I have had discussions with people, a lot of different people, and I had heard that even — well I'll give you an example. When I was playing with Lionel Hampton I didn't know this for a fact but a couple of the guys in the band had told me that during the 70s or 80s, when Lionel was putting a band together to tour Europe or Japan, that the promoters were concerned that there were too many white guys in the band, because they felt that a black band was authentic. Now it made no sense to me then and it makes no sense to me now. Because when I was in the band, in Lionel's band, it was an integrated group. He always had great musicians. I mean there was always a great pool of musicians to draw from. And I didn't understand it because I only thought that hey, they just want a great band. But it just goes to show that you can never take this stuff for granted and what some people are thinking about. But other than that I've never faced a racial issue like that.

MR: Sometimes I think people create one so they have something to write about.

SW: I think so. And honestly I think writers tend to write for each other. And I have seen some articles, as a matter of fact I have sort of taken a moratorium against some of the publications because I think — even some of the more popular music publications — because I have copies of articles from the 1960s and 70s, where the journalism is really getting into what it is about the musician, and what the musician is thinking about and what the musician is doing. Now it's, in the last ten years, it's become this hype machine. And it's really not about, at least always, it's not about the musician. It's about some other factor in the industry. And I've even read articles, I've even read reviews of my own records where writers are saying something, even when they're trying to say something positive, they're totally off base as to what I'm trying to do musically. And I look at it and go oh is that what I was thinking about. Oh I'm glad he knows. Because I wasn't thinking about anything when I wrote that. So I really do think that there are writers out there who are responsible. I think there are responsible journalists. But we now have more than our share of those who don't know the music, they don't understand what it is to be an artist, so they can't speak from that perspective, so what right do they

have to judge what artists are trying to do? So yeah, I think there's a negative effect out there right now.

MR: I love that statement you just made in passing, and that was "I wasn't thinking of anything when I wrote that." I mean can you talk about that? Because I think it's a very interesting thing and like you said I think sometimes we have to put a meaning on everything.

SW: Yeah. I remember having a conversation about three years ago with Gary Peacock. We were both doing the Montreal Festival. And I had never met him before and I had a really fascinating conversation with him. I was very honored that he was talking to me. But he told me about an instance when he was working with I think Albert Ayler or somebody like that. And of course at that time they were being pegged the angry black musicians, because they're playing avante garde or so-called avante garde. And Albert had read some review and whoever the writer was was talking about oh we can hear the anger and about being oppressed and about Vietnam and about this and about that. And Albert said, "Man, it ain't about nothing. It ain't about nothing." You know? So that stuck with me. Because a lot of times these writers, when you read these reviews, they will write something and it says that they're trying to tell the audience what we're trying to do. It's like well at least give us the courtesy of coming to us to let us explain what agenda we have, if any. Rather than taking this upon themselves to interpret our music for the benefit of the audience. No. And there's another interesting book, I think called *Composers on Music* which I had some years ago and lost it somewhere along the way. But it had composers from I think like Bach on through to Aaron Copland, and where they read reviews of their works and they were dealing with the same issues, where the critics were talking about how invalid their particular work was, or finding anything wrong with it that they could just to advance their own agenda, I'm talking about the writer. And it had the musicians writing to either like relatives or to each other in some instances, saying this critic is totally out of his mind, it had nothing to do with what I was working towards in this piece of music. So it's an age-old issue. It's nothing new.

MR: Yeah. When you write, are you getting to get more of your own tunes on records and so forth?

SW: Um hum.

MR: Do you write at the piano?

SW: Yeah. I write primarily from the piano, though I'm trying to change that now. I'm trying to write more from melody first now. So I'm using saxophone or flute to try to think of melodies.

MR: Does the creation of a new set of chords, is that a challenge to you?

SW: Um hum. Yeah. For instance if I'm taking a standard tune and I want to do something a bit different with it — like we had this arrangement of "'S Wonderful" that we do and now not that that tune needs anything reworked, because it's a great, immensely crafted tune, I mean we're talking about Gershwin so Gershwins don't need anybody to be writing anything. But certainly to make the tune to have it reflect the personality of the quartet we work with and — not to bring it up to date but to add a little twist — and as I'm arranging the tune I'm thinking about well what was another way that Gershwin might have conceived the tune? So in other words I don't want to reharmonize the tune to where it has nothing to do with the song. And I remember hearing Herbie Hancock some years ago, he had done an arrangement of I think "I Love You," the Cole Porter. And he basically modulated every eight bars I think it was. But it wasn't so far away from the original concept of the tune. So you could still think of the lyric and the melody staying intact, or at least the integrity of the lyric and the melody staying intact. So if I'm doing like a reharmonization, I'm not sitting there thinking like man how hip can I make this? How jazzed up can I make this? I'm thinking the opposite way. How true can I stay to the melody? How true can I stay to the integrity of the composition? And put some of my personality or our personality on it, and just add a little twist but not get away from what it's really about. And so when I'm writing my own music I'm thinking that way now. I'm not trying to see how difficult or how intricate or how hip I can make anything. I'm simply now trying to make a statement. And I'm finding that simplicity is the way to go. The simpler the better. So even if I've written something that seems to take on a little bit, a few more curves than I'd like, I'm trying to edit it down to get to the bare bones. It's much like a sculptor who is trying to get right to the core image.

MR: Yeah. I always like it when I hear a new song and after it's done I can remember it.

SW: Um hum.

MR: Which means it's got — to me anyway — it's got a distinctive melody.

SW: Absolutely. Yeah.

MR: Or some hook.

SW: Yeah. I agree. That's why now I'm trying to deal with melody. For years I wrote from chord changes simply because I was so fascinated by chords and what they could do. But now I'm trying to hear voice leading in those chords, I'm trying to hear melodies. So I'm now trying to get melodies first, before I even go to chord changes. Because I've found that oh, it's the melody that will dictate the chords. Not quite so much the other way around. And I find that there's a lot more freedom in that.

MR: I was pleased to see — I believe it's your last CD — that you have all the members of your working band on it.

MR: Is it hard to get to that place?

SW: It's very hard. It still is. Because all of these guys are first call musicians. So they end up doing a lot of different work, which is what we all do now, out of necessity. You have to be diversified. In order to make a living in this business you've got to be ready to jump into a lot of different situations. And it's hard to get consistent work with any one group now. I mean, which is what we were talking about the industry and the changes, that's probably the major thing that has changed. It is almost impossible for most of us to get consistent work with the same group. To put a tour together, the expenses, it usually doesn't pay for itself to put a tour together. So you can't just — as much as we love to play — we have to eat. I've got a kid to feed and the whole thing. So yeah, it's made it very difficult. But yeah we feel really lucky when we can to play together. I mean as we're talking Ed, our bassist, Ed Howard just returned from Japan a week ago. Bruce Barth, our pianist, just returned from Japan a couple of weeks ago. Adam Cruz is always on the road with different people, you know Danilo Perez, or, he's always on different stuff. And I stay pretty busy doing other things. So anytime we can put it together for more than a couple of days we feel very happy.

MR: I can imagine, just getting all four of you up here for three days, like schedules—

SW: Yeah. I mean as soon as we get back everybody's going — shhew — now fortunately a week from today as we speak we have a concert in Philadelphia where all four of us can actually make it. But the very next morning Ed is out to San Francisco with Shirley Horn. So that's the nature of the beast these days.

MR: What other kinds of gigs come your way?

SW: Well let's see. I freelance with a lot of different people as a sideman with Mulgrew Miller, James Williams, Buster Williams, various things in town, in New York I mean, either subbing for someone on a big band or working with other people in recording dates. I'm doing some teaching these days. So it's pretty diversified. I'm jumping all over the place. I was in Dayton, Ohio a week ago doing a residency there as part of their arts program and actually doing a concert with the quartet in March. I'll be going out there two more times working with high schools and colleges in different workshops and whatnot.

MR: We had mentioned the IAJE thing and it seems like it's almost a necessity these days for jazz musicians to get involved in the education scene.

SW: Yeah. Yeah I think fortunately, now I've seen the trend in the last ten years where more of the street musicians have gotten involved, musicians that are in the scene, of the scene, in addition to educators. And I think that's been a positive. I think Bunky Green had a lot to do with that when he was president, to get a lot of the musicians involved. Of course I

Ridley who were teaching at Rutgers and then you had Rufus Reid who was head of the program at William Paterson for many years and recently retired. So there has always been that factor involved. But in the more recent times we've seen a big influx of that. And I hope that turns out to be a positive. Because again, education is good. But without the oral tradition, to get the unteachable nuances so to speak of the music, the spiritual elements of the music, there's nothing like the oral tradition. There's nothing like taking a younger musician aside and saying hey you know what? Instead of doing it like that, think about it like this. Instead of counting in four-four, count in two-two, which is another thing I learned from Lionel Hampton. So all of those little things, and talking about the experiences that we've all had with each other, that's important in the development of young musicians. And we can't — the music cannot go forward without that. There are different ways to disseminate the information. We can always learn about chord changes about theory, which is great and I think it's necessary to be a professional working musician these days. But those other things, those other intangibles, it's always what made this music what it is. It is at its core and at its root, it's a folk music. This is really folk music first and foremost, and will always be. That's its greatness, that's part of its greatness. And I think any great music draws from that. So we can't lose it.

MR: Yeah. I agree. Sometimes you see in some of the magazines that you may have stopped reading, they analyze — they transcribe a solo and analyze it to death and every note has to have some function. Here's what the player was probably thinking why he played this B flat. I'm just like well maybe he didn't even mean to play that B flat.

SW: That's right.

MR: It's like he needed to keep playing.

SW: That's right. And that's what happens so many times but you're right. I mean sometimes a certain note or a group or notes has no agenda. Basically we forget that improvising, two things are happenings — of many things — but one we're expressing ourselves, and the other thing is we're trying to get from A to B in some kind of fluid fashion. And sometimes that means we're going to take detours. And we may play a group of notes that may have no theoretical relevance so to speak. But if you look at the whole statement then you are — hey now I see. And so yeah, you're absolutely right. You can only analyze this music so much and it was never — this music did not evolve out of academe. That came later. Even classical music, that did not — I mean all the analyzation and stuff, that came later. It was simply creating beautiful art. And that's what it should be about.

MR: I'm going to play a couple of tunes, just little pieces for you. I guess we could call it a blindfold test. I'm sure that —

[audio interlude]

SW: Yeah. Cannonball. I don't know the particular recording, obviously one of the live recordings. I wanted to say — not "Mercy Mercy" but there's a live recording called "I Know Why I Feel So Bad" something like that.

MR: Yeah. "Why am I Treated So Bad."

SW: "Why am I Treated So Bad."

MR: There you go.

SW: Yeah. Man Cannonball to me was the consummate altoist. His tone, his sound, his approach. And you look at his career, you could apply that tone to jazz, R&B, classical. When you listen to some of those records he did in the 50s with strings, the things —

MR: "Fiddler on the Roof."

SW: "Fiddler on the Roof," yeah. And there was another one like in the mid-50s, I can't remember the title of it, I think he's doing some Ellington pieces on there. And he's playing in a very classical-like tone, but very expressive and very beautiful, it almost sounds like a cello sometimes. But he had to me just the consummate concept of alto saxophone, which for a lot of people who don't know it's like I always tell people it's the easiest one to start on and the hardest one to master. The alto, playing it constantly has me in a headlock. It's a really difficult instrument to master, and I've had this conversation with just every other altoist. You know John Gorton, who is a wonderful altoist, we talk about this a lot. I've had this conversation with Kenny Garrett and we always talk about yeah man that alto, ooh. But we keep at it. But for Cannonball, yeah, one of my favorites.

MR: Yeah. He had such an electricity about him and his personality too. One of the few people who seemed comfortable talking with his audience and getting the music across from that standpoint.

SW: Yeah and that's very important. He was a great communicator both with and without the instrument. You listen to him talk, and he's very eloquent, but very funny at times and right to the point. And you just — I got the chance to see him live when I think I was maybe twelve years old. And he just brings you right into the music. He brings you right in. And you listen to those records, like "Country Preacher" you know. I used to listen to that record for him talking as much as him playing.

MR: Yeah.

SW: His inflections and what he was saying.

MR: You know that spot in the record where they're doing "Country Preacher" and the first time it hits that break and there's that silence? And when they come back in and the people go crazy.

SW: Right right.

SW: Yeah it's like church. Yeah. And that hit me directly. Because it was like going to church. So yeah Cannonball, to me represented the past, present and future. And he even mentions that on that record, when he talks about the past, present and future of our music.

MR: That's right.

SW: And that's really what it's about.

MR: Well let me see if I can negotiate this.

[audio interlude]

MR: Now this tune is all one change? Is that the idea?

SW: Um hum. Yeah I could talk about this one all day long. Yeah. Eddie Harris.

MR: That's Eddie Harris?

SW: Yeah. The original "Freedom Jazz Dance." Boy there's so many things we could talk about. What I usually point out to people, and particularly my students when I usually bring a recording of this in, because most young students when they learn "Freedom Jazz Dance" they learn Miles' version of it. And they've never heard this version, the original, and what it's really about. The real catalyst on this recording is Billy Higgins. Because you hear the whole tradition of black music in his playing on this, from New Orleans forward. You hear that second line, you hear Congo Square, you hear swing, you hear funk. It's dancing. It's all about dance. And he really — I remember listening to this record once about fifteen years ago and I used to listen to it over and over and over and over. And just to listen to Billy Higgins' snare drum on this record, just his snare. It's like a symphony. Because it keeps developing, it keeps going, it keeps opening up. And it is what is propelling Eddie and everybody else to play what they play. And most bass players don't know the original bass line that Ron is playing, just that one simple figure but it's what makes it. And Eddie, to me who is the unsung genius of saxophone and one of the unsung geniuses of this music, and he's probably been one of the biggest influences on me, one of the first people, well probably the first guy that I idolized so to speak, even before I could even pick up a saxophone, I used to love his records. I love him still but he covered the whole history of music. When you listen to all those different records he did in the sixties, where he's doing "Breakfast at Tiffany's" or "Exodus," and then "Freedom Jazz Dance," and then with his work with the electronics, which we talk about electronics and man this guy was ahead of everybody when it came to electronics, you know all the things he did: reed trumpet, saxophone mouthpiece on the trumpet, and that recording of "Oleo" where he's playing the tenor saxophone with a trombone mouthpiece.

MR: That one I'm not aware of.

SW: Yeah. They just re-released this record. It was one of the first records I was into after "Swiss Movement" was a record called "Excursions." And it was a two record set which came out in I think 1973 or '74. And it was a compilation of different sessions. Some of the things hadn't been released and on one of those tunes he's playing "Oleo." I don't remember who the band is right now but in the middle of the solo he plays a cappella and with the trombone mouthpiece on his tenor. I mean, amazing. And not just as a gimmick, but he really developed all this stuff. He was an amazing musician. And the language, he had his own language, the language he developed. Also on this record, I played for one of my students recently "Love For Sale" which is on this record. And to do what he does on that tune, you know, these fourth things, playing the tune, nobody was thinking about that when he did that. So to me Eddie is one of the great innovators, one of the great unsung geniuses man. We were listening on the way up here in the car I have a tape, an Eddie Harris record of him just talking, live in performances. I don't know if I can say the title, I don't know —

MR: No it's all right.

SW: Okay. "Eddie Harris Talking Shit." That's what it's called. And he's just going on and on talking about different things to the audience. But he was a true original, a true original man.

MR: Yeah he didn't seem to care — didn't he have an album called "I Need the Money."

SW: Yeah. "I Need Some Money."

MR: "I Need Some Money." You know it's like you just put it out there.

SW: Yeah. You know I never got to meet him personally, unfortunately. Because there's a small group of us who were big Eddie Harris fans. David Hazeltine, the great pianist, he played with Eddie for a bit. Johnny King is another great pianist. He's another Eddie Harris fan. And a young tenor player by the name of Mark Turner. There's a Eddie Harris fan club, we all get together and talk about it. Yeah, I just can't say enough about it man. Just a true genius. Could play anything. Could play anything. And master of altissimo long before some of the guys we think about now, but just a true master of it. Yeah.

MR: Well I have one more thing here which I'm sure you'll recognize.

[audio interlude]

MR: Do you listen to your own records very often?

SW: Not very often, only because I'm too self critical of my own, thinking oh if only I could have done this, or what was I thinking about, why did I play that, oh why did I sound that way?

MR: I mean you were after that, right? That kind of that little dissonant thing there?

SW: Oh yeah, yeah. Actually I was very happy with the way this particular cut came out

MR: Nice lines.

SW: Yeah. Yeah. There's a little story in the title of that and of course it's called "Q-B-Rab," which barbecue spelled backwards.

MR: Oh I was wondering.

SW: Yeah. And of course there's a couple of different connections to that. Of course it's a second line beat, which of course is from New Orleans so you can think about "Strutting with some Barbecue," of course a little homage to Louis Armstrong. But the actual title came from, I got it from a book from Bobby Seale who was of course the former Black Panther and later on became the professor at Temple University. And for a while he became famous for his barbecue recipes. And he had a book called *Q-B-Rab* with Bobby Seale.

MR: I'll be darned.

SW: So here we have a second line rhythm in an odd meter. So you can think about the barbecue part but with a little twist on it, you know, Q-B-Rab. So that's kind of the connection with the title. And of course Nicholas Payton being from New Orleans, I had him in mind when I wrote this piece.

MR: If a student was watching this interview and said a number of times you've mentioned the second line, they might not know what you're talking about.

SW: Yeah. A second line rhythm is like a rhythm from New Orleans. Now I don't know the exact origin of it. But I think it came out of what they used to call the Cakewalk from the late nineteenth century. And it was like a dance. And so you hear the second line rhythm a lot, like if you listen to recordings of "When the Saints Go Marching In" [scats] so it's sort of like a combination of a march and dance rhythm. And you hear that rhythm in groups like the Meters, who have an association with the Neville Brothers, Aaron Neville and the rest of the brothers from down there. So yeah, and actually that rhythm became popular again because of people like Wynton Marsalis and Jeff Watts, who when they came on the scene, and Donald Harrison and Terence Blanchard, they used that rhythm a lot in the compositions and it's become now a part of — a very common part of our language.

MR: It's funny when I was kind of choosing a couple of things to put here I went from the Eddie Harris thing and then I put your CD on and I found some similarity there between those two songs.

SW: Yeah, yeah, oh yeah absolutely. Because the foundation of what Billy Higgins is playing on "Freedom Jazz Dance" is right from second line. You can hear it it's right in there. Ed Blackwell is another one, the rhythms that he played came right out of second line. It was one of the rhythms that fed one of the seeds for swing to develop. Because there's triplet

that bounce. So certainly yeah, that's a part of it. And particularly in "Q-B-Rab," there's a lot of elements that I was addressing. And even the record, the whole recording, "Passages," which is the title of that, the purpose I guess that I had in mind was to bring together all of the influences that I've had as a musician and growing up and hearing all of these different kinds of music and jazz and R&B and funk, avante garde, within the thread of that tune you know you can find Eddie Harris, Ornette Coleman, you know, second line, Kool and the Gang, there's a figure in there right out of Kool and the Gang, "Hollywood Swinging" [scats].

MR: There you go, yeah.

SW: And that's what it is. And by the way in their pre-Kool and the Gang life they were a jazz group. And so I was very influenced by them, particularly Ronald Bell, who was heavily influenced by John Coltrane. So the music to me is all this incredible tapestry with these different threads. Or we could think about it with an amazing tree with all of these branches. And it's all music, it's all a continuum. And I try not to so much in my own music, try not to say well we can't allow ourselves to think this way because we're thinking that way. We all are who we are because of what we grew up with. We were all fed on different things, artistically and just as human beings. So I think the artist, being true to oneself brings all of that in. You know you can't deny who you are. You are who you are. So bring it all in there. That's what it's all about. That's what art is all about. Honesty. So bring it all in. And that's what I feel we were able to accomplish with this record.

MR: Yeah I believe so. And it seems like it's an innovation in a sense when you're bringing all those elements together because I've often wondered if it's constantly getting harder for people to become innovators.

SW: It's a good question. Well it gets back again to industry stuff because you know in the 80s and 90s you had this term neoclassism thrown around a lot when it came to jazz. And they would often associate Wynton Marsalis with well he's a neoclassicist because he's playing in the style of Miles or the style of Louis or whatever. I mean now the musicians never thought, we never sat around talking, "Yeah you know what? I'm going to play something in the neoclassicist style." You know? We never think that way. We're simply trying to create music from what we've grown up with and to evolve as artists. And only time can take care of what is innovation and what is now. Louis Armstrong, Charlie Parker, Duke Ellington, none of them ever sat down and said you know what I'm going to be an innovator. Yeah, I'll write something that will change the way people think about everything. I will play something that will change the way people play. None of them ever said that. They simply were pursuing their vision of music and art. I remember,

Nobel Peace Prize in 1969 or something like that. And when he was rejected for it and someone told him about it and Duke said, "Well I guess I wasn't supposed to be too famous too soon. And here's a guy who had been around for 50 years at that point and had already left an amazing legacy. And that just gives you a sense of where he was. He wasn't thinking about accolades or accomplishments. And of course now we know him to be probably one of the greatest innovators if not the greatest of twentieth century music period. Of any category. And his music was beyond category. So yeah, I think if we stay true to ourselves as artists, as musicians, and as human beings, the innovation will come. Time will take care of that legacy. We have to just do what we do and let everything else take care of itself.

MR: Well on that note I think we need to wrap up and get on to our next thing.

SW: Okay.

MR: Anything that you'd like to add here that I haven't hit on?

SW: Well I just want to say that I'm very privileged to be a part of this wonderful legacy that you all have here, I mean just the list of people that you've interviewed and the list of people you've had here at the college. It's very important what you're doing and I hope you continue it and I'm just very privileged and honored to be in this line of all the great musicians that have been here. So thanks very much for having me.

MR: Well thank you, my pleasure.

SW: We've had a ball.

MR: It's been a great pleasure for me.

SW: Thanks Monk.